

music

bageshwari qamar

SHEHNAI

Qamar is the first woman shehnai player to have stormed the male bastion. Her first guru was her father Pandit Jagdish Prakash Qamar who guided her during the early years. When she was seven years old, she told her mother that she wanted to learn the shehnai, often called the mangal vadya. "I had to do something different and my mother encouraged me to learn this instrument," says Qamar. In 1989 Ustad Bismillah Khan accepted her as his disciple.

When Qamar plays the shehnai, the notes strongly reflect her personality. They are resonant with her pleasant disposition and earthy demeanour. A mother of two, she does a balancing act between home and work, although she admits she would like to spend more time on practice. "Shehnai is my life. Without music, life will cease to have any meaning," says Qamar, who has released a jugalbandi album with her guru.



LEARN INSTRUMENTAL MUSIC AT:

Shriram Bharatiya Kala Kendra

Sarod, sitar and tabla classes are offered. Classes are held thrice a week, on alternate days. Time: 4 p.m. to 7 p.m. At: 1, Mandi House, Copernicus Marg. Fees: Rs 500 for beginners. Minimum age: 8 years. Call: 23386428/ 29, 23384068 for more details.

Matri Kala Mandir

Sitar, keyboard, Hawaiian guitar, Spanish guitar and tabla are taught here. Classes are held twice a week. At: Shri Aurobindo Ashram, Aurobindo Marg, inside Mother's International School campus. Time: One hour between 3.30 p.m and 6 p.m. Fees: Rs 350 to Rs 450. Call: 32425661.

Gandharva Mahavidyalaya

The institute has classes in sitar, violin, tabla, flute and harmonium. Eligibility: minimum 8 years old. Timings: Depends on the batch. Fees: Rs 1,000 admission fees and Rs 500 to be paid per month. At: 212, Deen Dayal Upadhaya Marg, ITO. Call: 23233791, 23238784.

Triveni Kala Sangam

The institute teaches tabla, flute and sitar. Tabla is taught in the evenings on Tuesdays, Thursdays and Saturdays, between 5 p.m. and 7 p.m. At: 205, Tansen Marg. Fees: Entry fees Rs 1,200 and monthly fees Rs 600. Sitar is taught thrice a week between 3 p.m. and 7 p.m. Fees: Rs 1,200. Call: 23718833.

take up instrumental music, which in any case required a great deal of physical strength. "One needs robust energy to hold the instrument and master the music," says Sharan Rani.

But was the tradition natural or invented? For, the mother of all instruments the rudra veena, has been depicted in temple architecture dating back to 500 AD, with a history going back to 5,000 years. Lord Shiva, say ancient scriptures, created this instrument inspired by his wife, Parvati. The rudra veena is thus not just a divine instrument, but a woman's instrument, too.

Somewhere down the centuries, that gender-neutral perception got blurred. "I feel male gurus think we can't rise to their standards. Therefore, they don't take women seriously," points out Anuradha Pal, a tabla player in Mumbai. There have been instances where women disciples have been exploited and looked down upon. "People come up to me and say, though you are a girl, you play well. Then there are some

who feel I cannot play for the entire length of the concert, on account of my gender," adds Pal.

Being a woman, most artistes have to cater to the two demanding roles—that of a homemaker and a performer. Added to this, vocalists usually rule the roost in the world of music. As accompanists, instrumentalists generally play second fiddle. For organisers and sponsors, wallets don't open up as easily for the latter. If you are a woman, the going gets so tough that most are forced to join a college or school, to teach instead of perform and eke out a viable existence. As one woman artiste points out, "Society is male chauvinistic. It is difficult to change it, so female artistes are expected to underplay their role. Worse, there is no promotion, help or recommendation from bigger artistes."

But talent speaks for itself. And mindsets change over time. The surge of women instrumentalists in our theatres and music halls today show how they have risen to the challenge and proved the traditionalists wrong.

■ by S. Sahaya Ranjit